Which Rival Weakness Should Our New Cozy Game Turn Into Its Strength?

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1 The decision

Which rival weakness should our new cozy game fix better than anyone? Owner: studio head, before development starts. If Story wins we invest in writing and characters; if Progression wins, in upgrades and pacing.

2 Why a network

Counting reviews shows which complaint is loudest, not how many different games share it. A one-game complaint is that game's problem, so we rank complaints by their degree in the game–complaint network.

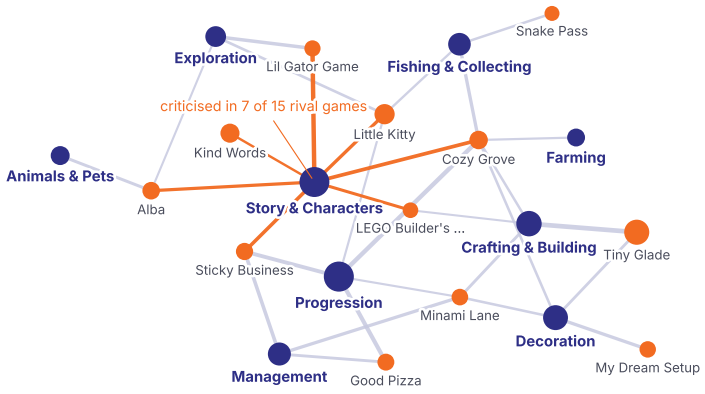
3 Data

Sources	3,407 newest negative Steam reviews (EN+TH, ≤300/game) of 15 top-reviewed paid cozy indie games
Legal basis	Documented public APIs (SteamSpy, Steam appreviews), 1 request/sec; no user IDs (PDPA)
Period	14 Sep 2019 – 13 Oct 2026
Sampling bias	Almost all English (7 Thai); silent quitters missing. One source is enough: buyers read these

4 Graph construction

Node / edge	Game or complaint topic (EN/TH keyword lists; hand check of 60 random matches: 68% correct, Story 77%). Edge = topic in ≥10% of a game's reviews (≥5), once per review
Weighting	Share of the game's reviews, not NPMI: NPMI scores what is unusual for one game, so it down-weights complaints common to many games. Tested: same winner (7 → 6 games)
Pruning	Removed cozy words (the seed) and generic complaints: bugs, price, too short/boring. Kept in, "too short/boring" would rank first, but it gives no design direction
Result	21 nodes (12 of the 15 games, 9 topics), 31 edges; 3 games had no link above the cutoff

5 The graph · orange = games, navy = complaints, orange lines = Story & Characters, thicker = higher share



Complaint	Games	Reviews	Top 1
Story & Characters	**7**	**430**	**20%**
Progression	**5**	**434**	**25%**
Crafting & Building	4	283	41%
Decoration	4	267	27%
Management	3	214	36%
Fishing & Collecting	3	203	36%
Exploration	3	155	30%
Animals & Pets	1	113	26%
Farming	1	90	40%

Reviews = keyword-matched negative reviews.
Top 1 = share from the biggest game

6 Findings

- **The loudest complaint is not the widest.** Progression has the most mentions (434 vs 430) but degree 5 (only 5 games), so a review count alone would pick it; degree shows Story is shared by more rivals.
- **Story & Characters is the shared weakness.** Highest degree: 7 of 15 rival games, and no single game gives over 20% of its mentions, so it is not one bad game's problem.
- **Robustness.** First in 7 of 9 cutoff settings (our pre-set bar), in all 15 leave-one-game-out runs and in 487 of 500 bootstrap resamples. Progression wins only at the loosest cutoff (5%), when weak links are let in.

7 Recommended action

Goal: "characters players remember" as our standout feature, tested before we commit.

- **23 Oct 2026 · studio head:** sort the 430 story complaints by type (no story, flat characters, weak dialogue) and pick the most common to fix.
- **13 Nov 2026 · design team:** playtest a story-first vs. a progression-first prototype with 20 cozy players. Go story-first if 12 or more prefer it.
- **Jan 2027 · analyst:** re-run after the Steam Winter Sale; switch if Progression reaches more games.

8 What would change my mind

Complaints show frustration, not buying: a game can be criticised for its story and still sell. The playtest settles it: if fewer than 12 of 20 prefer story-first, I switch to Progression.